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The Clock Room and the Macro-Cognitive Accounting Framework—Mapping-Chain Analysis of AI, Finance, and Algorithmic Platforms: A Reader's Guide to Volume V

Reading Guide Volume V: Governance, Endgame, and the Flood Myth

Volume V brings execution capacity, material conditions, urban space, technological routes, and institutional design together, asking whether governance can alter the actual boundaries of the system—and why critique itself may also stall. The book thereby moves from diagnosis into institutional imagination, without writing that imagination as a finished answer.

The eight chapters fall into four segments. Chapters 31–33 first treat agentic AI, the material substrate, and the city; Chapters 34 and 35 analyze the historical selection of AI routes and the algorithmic central bank; Chapters 36 and 37 return to temporal asymmetry and agency; Chapter 38 closes the book with semimodernity and rooted globalism.

I. Execution, Material Conditions, and the City

Chapter 31: When the Clock Begins Opening Doors for People—An MCAF Projection of Agentic AI

Agentic AI extends readings and recommendations into physical or digital execution. Earlier media mainly changed what people could see and how they could react; the execution channel enables a system, once authorized, to complete operations directly. The topology of the media conductivity coefficient thereby changes: the mapping chain enters not only judgment but also actual change in the external world.

The execution channel can bypass the user's comparison, stopping, and withdrawal, and the consequences of fibers may thereby acquire irreversible physical form. Micro-level meta-audit capacity is physically bypassed; will offloading is no longer only a question of the speed of judgment but concerns whether one is still willing to retain review and refusal; the biological substrate and the legitimacy base cannot shoulder the whole defense alone. The main text is more concrete: the Agent executed dozens of API calls in the background—the user only sees "task completed." If one of those calls caused damage (leaked data, deleted a file), the user is completely ignorant until the damage manifests. This is the extreme form of the debt clock (τ_d) defined in Chapter 3, §3.2, in the Agent scenario: the time lag between the deposition and manifestation of debt is further widened by the Agent's black-box operations.

The machine-to-machine (M2M) closed loop magnifies the risk of mistaking mutual confirmation for calibration. Two systems confirming each other does not automatically provide external reality; the more operations enter execution without verification, the greater the needs for tracing and correction, and their actual cost also depends on error rates, reversibility of consequences, and log completeness. The strength of mutual-confirmation evidence and the costs of auditing must be assessed separately.

The traditional compensation loop is strained at three points: the causal chain becomes a causal web, raising the cost of reconstruction; victims may not know that they have been harmed; and the damage often crosses the classificatory boundaries of existing law. The main text illustrates the causal web: from "the Agent read an email containing malicious instructions" to "the company's confidential files were sent to the attacker," the process passes through prompt parsing, tool invocation, identity verification, network transmission, and multiple other links; each link has multiple possible failure points. Execution-layer circuit breakers, legal identity, and non-bypassable stop signals therefore become objects of governance, not merely matters of output quality. The capacity to stop execution and the capacity to correct output are two different capacities, and both must be retained.

Governance of agents must therefore embed non-bypassable stop signals in the execution layer—cumulative execution budget, suspension and confirmation of irreversible operations, multi-model cross-validation, and grounding measures—and stipulate legal identity and boundaries of responsibility at the institutional layer. The main text gives these measures their image: the execution budget is the cavity of the bowl—not eliminating efficiency, but preserving a "nothing" within efficiency; the delay is the emptiness of the axle hole—creating a gap in the clock's rotation, within which the opportunity for a minimal human review is preserved. Diagnostic information cannot by itself determine risk level: when key evidence cannot be verified, high-risk operations should be suspended—they must not be released on the model's self-report of being "grounded." Such measures raise operating costs and reduce speed, running counter to competitive pressure; their implementation depends

on the institutional layer stipulating minimum control requirements and boundaries of responsibility.

Chapter 32: The Great Acceleration—AI's Material Substrate, Positive Feedback Loops, and Planetary Boundaries

Data centers, energy, capital, and infrastructure form the material substrate of AI. A model is not a purely informational object floating in the cloud: training, deployment, and daily invocation all require electricity, equipment, land, networks, and labor. The chapter opens with these words: "This sentence is burning. This is not merely a metaphor. In a physical sense: the text you are reading, at the moment it was generated, consumed electricity and dissipated heat—and, following the cooling configuration of the data center, consumed or evaporated water, and, following the generation mix of the supplying grid, emitted carbon into the atmosphere." These physical events occurred in invisible places—on some row of servers in some data center, in some transmission line of some power grid, on the surface of some river or reservoir. They will not appear on the screen, nor in the bill (the subscription fee paid for AI has no line item called "carbon emissions"), nor in the AI's own replies.

Demand, investment, deployment, and resource consumption form positive feedback, but environmental costs do not always enter existing ledgers. Efficiency gains may lower unit costs, yet may also offset the savings by expanding total use; indicators of technological progress therefore cannot by themselves prove that overall pressure is falling. The main text names this mechanism as the possible reappearance of the Jevons Paradox in the AI domain: efficiency improvements may release suppressed demand by lowering marginal cost; when the released demand exceeds the savings per task, total consumption rises. This mechanism is particularly dangerous because it converts "good news" (efficiency improvements) into a bad outcome (increased total consumption), thereby making the narrative that "technological progress will solve the problem" itself part of the problem.

The chapter's indicator analysis keeps both the forward side and the shadow: compute, investment, and output show expansion; electricity, emissions, and resource occupation show the costs. Four loops and one mechanism track mutual reinforcement; the second derivative examines whether acceleration continues to alter acceleration itself; fracture-point analysis is therefore as important as planetary boundaries.

Planetary boundaries force cognitive-debt accounting to meet physical accounting. Cognitive pollution and physical environmental damage can reinforce one another, and the appropriation of benefits and the bearing of costs may be distributed across regions, groups, and periods. Whether a positive feedback holds must still be verified case by case; analogy cannot replace measurement.

The "impossible accounting" is not an abandonment of accounting, nor a claim that these costs cannot be measured: it is the claim that no single accounting indicator can yield the full environmental consequences and the full case for a deployment—carbon pricing exposes this limit at the three levels of attribution, time, and boundary; which burnings purchase real output and which merely produce illusion and sycophancy is not something that kilowatt-hours, tons of carbon, or dollars of GDP can distinguish in advance.

Chapter 33: When the City's Clock Is Replaced—Real Estate, Finance, and the Discrete Leviathan

The city is originally a clock of ecology, relations, and life. The chapter opens by stating: the city is not a container—it is a kind of clock, but a special kind of clock: it simultaneously points to the sun. The density of pedestrians on the street reveals whether this area is prosperous; the lights of the shops reflect whether the economy is active; the faces of neighbors show whether the community is stable. These signals are not indicators compiled by any institution—they are the direct effusion of true states (T); the mapping function (π) is minimal, the fiber is very small, and they can be received by the body almost without decoding. The financialization of real estate and the attention economy have successively altered these readings and their ecological functions, so that the city is gradually redescribed by asset prices and platform traffic.

The order of the two de-anchorings cannot be reversed: the financialization of real estate first changed the city's asset readings; the attention economy then reshaped the city's service and relational functions. Office real estate, street-level shops, and back-staged spaces display different consequences of de-anchoring, and pseudo-small fibers may also eliminate the small-fiber clocks that once recorded local change. The main text characterizes the manufacture of the pseudo-small fiber in three steps: the Discrete Leviathan does not replace the city's information-processing function out of thin air; it manufactures a pseudo-small fiber whose perceived fiber is minimal and whose real fiber is vast—a cognitive illusion "more precise," "more real-time," and "more personalized" than the city. Step One: capturing attention—manufacturing a zero-friction information environment, substantially lowering the natural friction of urban physical space through infinite scrolling, autoplay, and one-click ordering. Step Two: re-encoding urban space into standardized readings—the "4.8-star restaurant" appears more "precise" than walking around the street and judging with one's senses—this precision of the readings conceals the inflation of the fiber. Step Three: eliminating the contrast conditions necessary for auditing—old-style neighborhoods are marginalized by the algorithm for lacking "check-in value"; users cannot scroll to them, and thus do not consider them to exist.

The Discrete Leviathan—a network of key nodes defined by four discriminant conditions (serial control, substitution cost asymmetry, trans-sovereign reach, and capital structure reflexivity), not a unified actor—manifests at the urban scale as three sets of observable consequences: the capitalization output at the capital market end, a trans-sovereign reachable digital substrate, and the structural replacement of the information-processing functions of the city's physical space. The real estate crisis offers different national variants of the settlement of de-anchoring; global isomorphism must not be written as if every country's mechanisms were identical.

The three layers of irreversibility appear in the city as information loss (the input of readings pre-filtered), dynamic corrosion (the spaces that survive are not those better to live in, but those better to photograph), and ontological dimensionality reduction (the city's state space projected onto photographability, ratability, and communicability). Preventing de-anchoring therefore cannot stop at updating valuation mechanisms; the fundamental direction is to protect the city's "nothing"—preserving forms of public use that do not take platform exposure, ratings, and instant monetization as conditions of access, so that people can still observe, interact, and verify independently outside platform readings.

Urban analysis finally returns to the time dimension. The life-world cannot be wholly replaced by asset prices and platform traffic, and local relations and continuing habitation cannot be settled by a single valuation. The nested relation between the state and the Discrete Leviathan likewise requires analysis by concrete institutions.

II. Route Selection and Institutional Imagination

Chapter 34: The Historical Selection of Artificial Intelligence Paths—The State, Academia, Capital, and the Alternative Field (1943–2026)

State funding, academic factions, the capital environment, and the alternative field jointly select AI routes. The main text defines the term strictly: a selection mechanism refers to the structural forces that determine which technological paths receive resources, are scaled, and enter historical writing. It is not equivalent to "scientific correctness"—many paths later deemed correct were screened out at the time; nor is it equivalent to "market demand"—many paths with demand were suppressed by non-market mechanisms. Each selection mechanism contains a selection function: an implicit or explicit criterion used to score paths. The historical stages do not form a progress narrative leading necessarily to the current mainstream: from 1990 to 2008, the capital field had already effectively intervened in the subset of statistical learning and pattern recognition stripped of the AI label; only after 2009 did the capital selection field begin to do large-scale work on research paths wearing the AI label themselves—and only on particular directions within them.

Early state funding, the evaluations of academic communities, the first winter, the long low-rate era, and the later divergence of financing each altered the time, equipment, and organizational conditions available to research routes. A route's survival therefore depends not only on internal performance but also on how long the external environment allows it to wait.

Low interest rates and balance-sheet expansion are not sufficient conditions; Japan's boundary experience shows that identical monetary conditions do not automatically produce identical technological results. The main text supplies the mechanism of the Japanese case: the same low interest rates and central-bank balance-sheet expansion, owing to the alienation of capital channels, the concentrated bets of state capital, and the absorption of low-cost funds by zombie loans, produced no multi-route parallel landscape—banks used low-cost funds for fake reorganization ("evergreening") of borrowers that should have gone bankrupt, and the consequence was not resource scarcity but that zombies depressed market prices and raised labor prices, making it harder for healthy firms to enter and invest. Nor can monetary conditions be written as an agent that directly determines the fate of technology: the capital environment, financing standards, and the alternative field require layered analysis.

The comparison of more than eighty years explains which routes obtained resources, which migrated in silence, and where cross-field mathematical connections stop. The orthogonal selection of the alternative field keeps the silenced routes from being mere historical footnotes and makes them an important contrast for testing the mainstream narrative.

The periodization from 1943 to 2026 is only a tool for organizing evidence, not a claim that synchronized turns occur at every date. The current mainstream is not the only possibility; historical selection cannot be written after the fact as natural selection; and different countries, institutions, and research traditions require separate determination of timing and mechanisms.

Chapter 35: Endgame Conditions and Institutional Imagination—From Data Exhaustion to the Algorithmic Central Bank

Data exhaustion, infrastructure concentration, and the absence of a compensation loop push the governance question forward to who sets the loss function. The chapter opens with a set of figures: in 2025, the combined market capitalization of the key nodes hit by the Discrete Leviathan discriminant function (the several U.S. technology companies aggregated by the capital markets under the Mag 7 label) surpassed the total GDP of the EU-27; these nodes simultaneously control the compute layer, data layer, model layer, and distribution layer of the global digital infrastructure, and unilaterally set the internal parameters of AI models—the loss function, the RLHF reward, temperature—parameters that directly determine the quantity and quality of the cognitive output received daily by billions of people; no public institution has yet established an audit regime for the parameters of the loss function themselves. A structural comparison between platform power and central-bank power is used to analyze the centralized processing of public resources, the pricing of attention, and the lack of public constraint—not to equate platforms directly with national central banks.

The union of three powers means that these companies simultaneously act as legislator, central bank, and commercial bank—designing the loss function, setting inference parameters, and directly lending cognitive output—implying the absence of external checks. Market mechanisms fail through network effects, cognitive capture, information asymmetry, and cross-platform isomorphism; the logic of traditional regulation is to set rules, conduct ex post inspections, and fine violations—but the speed of algorithmic iteration far exceeds the speed of regulation, the specific parameters of the loss function cannot be audited, and causal ambiguity makes accountability difficult—and, more fundamentally, the rules themselves are private.

The algorithmic central bank is proposed as a public-boundary scheme of institutional imagination, modeled on the historical evolution of central banks and financial regulation. A public audit fund, mandatory interfaces, boundary audits, and public constraints aim to keep the loss function and the rules of admission from being decided wholly by private goals; what they target is the asymmetry of capacities for goal-setting, verification, contestation, and correction.

The histories of the Bank of England, the Federal Reserve, and the Basel Accords show that public institutions are often crisis-driven and iterated over the long run. The main text argues from this that AI governance cannot rely on "learning from mistakes"—because the lessons of mistakes may be washed away by the next round of technological iteration before they are institutionalized. Financial regulation offers a reference: from the exposure of Basel II's institutional defects in 2004, to crisis validation in 2008, to the Basel III remedy in 2010, the learning cycle was approximately six years; in the AI domain, waiting for crises to provide lessons may be an institutionally unaffordable strategy. The discussion of universal basic income as circular rent cannot replace the compensation loop and public auditing either: income distribution may relieve some consequences, but it does not automatically alter the control of infrastructure or the authority to audit.

The scheme is accompanied by fundamental difficulties: it cannot print reality, cannot eliminate all fibers through public power, and international coordination, model auditing, and ideological auditing all require actual conditions. The main text's formulation is: a financial central bank can "print money" in a crisis—the algorithmic central bank cannot "print out reality"; when model collapse threatens the reliability of AI systems, the algorithmic central bank cannot "inject liquidity" to solve the problem, because the root of the problem is the exhaustion of genuinely human data, and genuinely human data cannot be manufactured. This is not an

endgame but the starting point of the governance discussion. Institutional design cannot exempt anyone from continuing judgment, nor can publicization itself be written as an answer requiring no audit.

III. Time, Critique, and Agency

Chapter 36: Temporal Asymmetry and the Stalling of Critique

The techno-capital clock, the ecological clock, and the governance clock do not run in step. Technological deployment can proceed monthly or quarterly; consequences may take years to identify; governance must wait for evidence, procedures, and organization. The temporal gaps among the three cannot be written simply as the sluggishness of governors.

Snapshot knowledge may freeze objects still in change. The main text pushes this into knowledge production itself: all environmental impact assessments, academic studies, and investigative reports—including this book—are snapshots: they collect data at a temporal slice, subsequently analyze and argue from that data, and deliver conclusions to the reader at an even later time; when the object being analyzed grows exponentially, the usefulness of the data as an estimate deteriorates sharply. The chapter offers an arithmetic example (the growth rate is compatible with the International Energy Agency's 2022–2026 forecast, and the publication cycle is stipulated for illustration; neither is presented as a statistical claim): if global data-center electricity use grows at 15% to 20% per year and a paper takes 18 months from data collection to publication, the scale the paper describes has already grown by roughly 23% to 32% by the time of publication—this is not because the author's calculations were erroneous, but because reality did not wait for the paper to be completed. Evaluations, audits, and critiques, once detached from their timestamps, may take a past state for a present fact. Governance may also retreat while running at full speed, and critiques that were once effective may even become a new source of delay.

The diagnosis of 1955 stands in contrast with the present, showing that the speed differential is not new, though different technological structures change its expression. Critique itself must also submit to temporal review: from which stage does the evidence come, do the conclusions still apply to current deployments, and have subsequent consequences altered the original judgment?

The "time-consuming Xiangyuan" reminds readers that formally continuous reflection may merely occupy the time one needs for dealing with consequences, without changing action. The main text's analysis: many "AI ethics" roundtable discussions, corporate sustainability reports, multi-stakeholder forums, and academic papers (including this one) do one thing—they channel attention, intellectual resources, and capacity for collective action into a range whose agenda is constrained by funding conditions and procedural rules; to identify this restriction as a Xiangyuan mechanism, it is not enough to prove that the activity acknowledged the risks—one must also show that the acknowledgment of risk was used to substitute for time-limited, verifiable action while the relevant investments continued to lock in. When a critic spends two years writing a paper arguing that the water consumption of AI data centers has been underestimated, during those two years the data-center water use of Google alone grew by roughly forty percent according to company disclosure; the paper's conclusion remains logically valid, but the window of decisions it could affect may already have closed—because the facilities it targeted have already been built. If critique is to retain its force, it must explore forms with lower time costs, sharper timeliness, and tighter embedding in decision windows, rather than remaining within the standardized rhythm of papers and forums.

Temporal asymmetry thus constrains not only technological deployment but also the updating of critique and governance themselves. Any audit report covers only the time point of its evidence and cannot write a stage-specific judgment as a permanent conclusion. Governance needs updating; so does criticism—otherwise both will fall behind technological change together.

Chapter 37: Agency Is All You Need—Safeguarding Human Agency through Meta-Audit

Agency cannot be reduced to whether a system responds, nor can it be wholly outsourced by a single act of authorization. The medieval church, printing, and the AI black box form a historical contrast: the mapping function can be concentrated, and the channels of interpretation and correction can also be reopened by technology—but new technology does not automatically guarantee that openness. The main text distinguishes three levels in three sentences: attention is the most basic thing a person does—looking; meta-audit is the higher-order thing a person does—questioning what one sees; agency manifests in this—even without an explicit request, a person can still decide whether to attend and whether to question.

The second derivative of narrative load advances the question from visible opinions to the grammar that governs expression. Individualism and Western centrism affect not only what the system says, but also what kinds of subjects, experiences, and calibrations are taken as defaults. Civilizational vulnerabilities therefore differ, and no single model of the subject can cover all societies.

The governance clocks of China, the United States, and the European Union, together with the two archetypal strategies of the Ark and flood control, provide a comparison of institutional paths. America's projection-side expansion, the EU's procedural legitimacy, and China's institutional-layer meta-audit display different governance clocks, each with shared limits. The main text characterizes the temporal nature of flood control: Yu the Great spent thirteen years (the *Records of the Grand Historian*, "Annals of the Xia," records him "living outside his home for thirteen years, not daring to enter his house even when he passed its gate") performing sustained work amidst the continuous flood, gradually channeling, until the water returned to its place. This is a continuous operation—not discretizing the system and rebooting, but modifying its structure while the system is in operation. Discretization and system reboot, channeling and continuity, cannot be taken directly as universal prescriptions.

Meta-audit is here restored to human agency: not to await perfect salvation, but to maintain the position from which one can audit, refuse, correct, and bear. That civilization exists for the sake of human beings means not only receiving services, but that people can still participate in defining the purposes and boundaries of those services.

The conditions of action for individuals and institutions differ, but both must retain a place for meta-audit. Refusing an output, amending a rule, or rebuilding independent evidence is not an exit from the current technological relations; it is preserving, within that use, the space to verify with one's own judgment.

IV. Postface: Semimodernity and Rooted Globalism

Chapter 38: Postface—Semimodernity and Rooted Globalism

The book finally returns to "semimodernity": the great expansion of material capacity does not automatically improve the conditions of relations, judgment, and habitation. The main text states the imbalance more concretely:

industrial systems and global connectivity have kept expanding, greatly increasing the capacity to alleviate material scarcity; modernization at the interpersonal level has never begun—humans still rely, when dealing with their relationships with one another, on what Hsu called "the magical mode of thinking": taking the discretized, atomized individual as the ontological default for the person, substituting role relations for affective relations, compensating for the absence of intimate bonds with non-human objects. The cycle of destruction and reconstruction can escalate endlessly, while affection, responsibility, and common life need not improve with it.

Individual judgment, affective chains, and the stable Holocene window of dwelling constitute the conditions of existence on three nested scales. The main text specifies each: at the individual scale, it is the existence of the human being as a judging subject—holding judgment apart from calculation; at the relational scale, it is the existence of affective chains between persons; at the dwelling scale, it is that stable Holocene window within which the human being can dwell as human on the Earth. They are interdependent yet non-substitutable, and cannot serve as compensation items after output. They are presuppositions of output's having meaning, not a line in the performance table that gains can offset.

Laozi's "Therefore this is how what is there provides benefit and how what is not there provides functionality" brings another ledger of the book into view: friction, pause, silence, non-response, and redundancy are not merely losses of efficiency but conditions under which judgment and calibration become possible. Cognitive environmental pollution and physical environmental damage form two global public harms, and the privatization of benefits with the socialization of costs links the two ledgers together.

MCAF is itself an act of discretization and cannot complete the other half of modernity. It cannot predict crises or rank civilizations; it can only compel the recording of both ends of each cognitive transaction. Bookkeeping is not the end: seeing the difference, continuing the verification, and maintaining action in the time dimension are what the framework can retain.

Rooted globalism is not a common model but mutual translation proceeding from the equilibrium ideals of different civilizations, while acknowledging the global transmission of infrastructure and evaluative defaults. The main text stresses its epistemological character: rooted globalism is not an institutional plan, not a movement, not a slogan; it is an epistemological stance—the audit of any single civilization alone is no longer sufficient to identify systemic risk, and the perspective of another equilibrium ideal must be enlisted to mutually illuminate blind spots. A common destiny does not mean a common model, and changing the configuration of control does not automatically solve the problem of judgment being silently exchanged for computation. What the book finally leaves is not a technological endgame, but reasons to continue auditing, doing work, and protecting "non-being."

V. The Close of Volume V and of the Book

Volume V concentrates the problems of the first four volumes on the conditions of governance: the calibration language of Volume I must be converted into boundaries of execution; the engineering diagnoses of Volume II into mechanisms of stopping and compensation; the financial history of Volume III into institutional reference; and the Discrete Leviathan and promises of Volume IV into public constraints and arrangements of responsibility.

Agentic AI, the material substrate, and the city show that cognitive debt occurs not only at the informational layer but also enters the physical environment and the space of life. Technological routes and the algorithmic central bank show that governance requires both an awareness of historical selection and a public institutional imagination—yet no scheme can be exempt from auditability, international coordination, and the bearing of consequences.

Temporal asymmetry and meta-audit return the book's method to the reader: conclusions must be bound to timestamps, critique must be able to update, and the subject must retain the position of judgment. Governance is not accomplished once; calibration is not a one-time repair; both require continuing work.

The book finally does not demand a uniform choice between "advance" and "prohibit." What must continue to be asked is whether independent evidence can enter, whether those affected can raise objections, whether rules can be changed, whether consequences can return to the responsible parties—and whether human judgment, relations, and conditions of habitation are still preserved. The clock is not time, and the reading is not the real; protecting "non-being," redundancy, and the capacities for calibration at every level is the practical direction the book leaves behind.